

beliefs into their own religion. The Romans tolerated people of all religions except those, like Christians, who refused to worship the emperor as well.

It was also thought that the spirits remained in or around their tombs, where they could receive offerings. On the birthday of the dead person or during festivals for the dead,

EACH FAMILY HAD ITS OWN GUARDIAN SPIRIT, OR GENIUS.

Death and beyond

The Romans believed in life after death, but they had various ideas of what it would be like. A common belief was that spirits traveled to a gloomy dark Underworld (land of the dead), which they would reach by crossing the great River Styx. The dead were often buried with a small coin under their tongue. This was to pay Charon, the ferryman who rowed souls across the River Styx.

Once across the vast river, the dead passed Cerberus—a monstrous three-headed guard-dog who prevented souls from sneaking back over the Styx to the land of the living.

families would visit the tomb and share a meal with them.

Religion of the Christians

In the 1st century CE, in the Roman province of Judea (modern-day Israel, Palestine, and Jordan), a new religion began. It quickly gained many converts, who became known as Christians. They were followers of the teachings of Jesus of



TWO SOULS STEP INTO CHARON'S BOAT TO BE ROWED OVER THE RIVER STYX.